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Hope in Buddhism and Hinduism

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Introduction

Hope manifests in many different aspects as part of Buddhist and Hindu teachings. This is true even if hope is not explicitly or directly referred to. Buddhists and Hindus live their lives with thousands of stories, myths, and legends. This we can find likewise in many other religions. In many of these stories hope for the better plays a large part. Both religions are diverse and evolving. The teachings of the Buddha or the Hindu god(s) are constantly being reinterpreted. While the Buddha was a supreme teacher, who pioneered and defined some of the fundamental principles of what in due course was to develop into Buddhism, later disciples and teachers continued to contribute to new practices and ideas to cater to contemporary needs. Meanwhile, ancient gods and scriptures of the Hindus inspired many contemporary gurus and sages and continue to do so. New teachings, practices, and scriptures are endlessly added to the vast tradition we call Hinduism today. It is therefore almost impossible to engrave a definitive understanding of them without limiting any attempt to a specific school of thought or a certain period. In the process, one must be cautious of superimposing "a reified conceptual unity" on the "plurality" (Barua 2017) of both traditions from their origin and evolution over the centuries. Particularly in the discussion of a practical subject like hope, it is important to analyze not only how hope is defined and explained in scriptures and authoritative texts but also to investigate how hope is perceived and how it gets its shape as a living part of religion and culture. In the case of Hinduism, Kumar (2010) distinguishes between the Brahmanical and non-Brahmanical Hindu societies. He argues that a deep understanding of the tradition would require more than just the elite Brahmanical lens (which is done quite often). It is equally important to engage in field studies of how the ordinary Hindu acts and thinks surrounded by the narrative of everyday society and local traditions. In fact, a researcher realizes that, for instance, a local Hindu in a small village may not strictly adhere to the master narrative of Viṣṇu in accordance with the Brahmanical perspective. In many cases, one may find this to be completely different. Diversity is an overall characteristic of Hinduism.

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This research hopes to analyze the relevance of hope and the various shapes it can take in both ancient religions, its significance to human developments, how hope plays a role in practices, and how it manifests in the minds and acts of Hindus and Buddhists. While Buddhism and Hinduism share similar roots from the Indian subcontinent with some comparable discussions on hope, their understandings of hope and how hope works may bring out differences as well. Moreover, both religions, but mainly Buddhism, reached other countries far away from India. Buddhism interacted with belief systems and practices already present there. This chapter first presents Buddhist perspectives of hope, then those of Hinduism, followed by an overview of their main similarities and their differences. While these analyses are first of all conducted through the lens of academic studies, it is also important to supplement the findings with practical considerations. As presented further below, as much as it is important to define and demonstrate what hope is or is not in Buddhism and Hinduism, it is crucial to simply answer the question: Are Buddhism and Hinduism hopeful or simply hopeless religions? In Buddhism and Hinduism, where could we find hope and how is it part of practices and belief? These questions are not as much epistemological as they are soteriological, significant to alleviate human suffering, despair, and hopelessness.

Buddhist Perspectives of Hope

In Buddhist teachings we may find very different words for and understandings of the concept of "hope." These may differ widely from what the common English word "hope" evokes. Moreover, there are many sacred scriptures in Buddhism in various languages. These languages do not all coincide when it comes to words for hope. Various associations and cultural peculiarities play a part here. Or they may do so. One thing to keep in mind is that Buddhism is not a unity. There are three major schools that are each further divided. These three share similarities, but there are differences as well. Here we will pay attention to hope in these three major divisions: *Theravāda*, *Mahāyāna*, and *Vajrayāna*. It is important to keep in mind that all of these schools claim to have access to what the Buddha truly and originally meant with his instructions. We will bring in ideas from primary and secondary sources and studies from these three schools. There is yet another aspect to mention here. An interesting development in Buddhist studies are the rather recent contributions of the so-called researcher-practitioner. This term is used for the researcher who studies Buddhism as an academic but brings in his or her personal experiences from Buddhist practice, most commonly experiences from the personal practice of meditation. We include these researcher-practitioners here because they play a major role in modern Buddhism. In many cases they quote from various Buddhist sources and refer to these leaving behind the distinctions of *Theravāda*, *Mahāyāna*, and *Vajrayāna*. Researcher-practitioners are these days found all over the globe, not only in Asia. For modern researcher-practitioners the just mentioned strict distinctions between the three schools are at times of

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lesser importance. But in some cases we will follow them as to how they perceive Buddhist teachings and the role of hope in these.

If we look at the authoritative Pāli scriptures, the main authority for the *Theravāda* school, there are a few relevant words connected to hope—or at least to what a human can long for (Mahathera 1958): *apekkhā* (also *apekhā*: Sanskrit: *apekṣā:* hope, desire, expectation); *ākaṅkhā* (Sanskrit: *ākaṅkṣā:* longing, wish, desire); and *abhilāsā* (Sanskrit: *abhilāṣā*: wish, longing, desire), which may capture the meaning of hope. In many cases in the Pāli scriptures these specific words are, however, associated with the more negative side of hope: hope as forms of wrong attachments, as clinging, and as evil inclinations that urge us on from one experience to the other. It is exactly these aspects of hoping and longing that should be controlled. There is another set of words: *pasāda* (Sanskrit: *prasāda:* faith, freedom from doubt, or clarity, translucence, sensitivity; Dhammajoti 2013) or *saddhā* (Sanskrit: *śraddhā*) which denotes faith, confidence (Acharya 2002), and trust (Keown 2004). The distinction between the first group (*apekkhā, ākaṅkhā, ākankhā, abhilāṣā*) and the second group (*pasāda, saddhā*) is that the first group corresponds to unwholesome qualities of unwished desire, as well as blind, irrational, baseless, or rootless "faith" (*amūlikā saddhā*); the second group corresponds to confidence based on reason, experience (*ākāravatī saddhā*), and trust. Therefore, this second group is considered wholesome. Faith can also be a wholesome mental factor preceding all other types of wholesome mental actions expressing our confidence in "*Buddha*, *Dhamma*, *Saṅgha* and in the Buddha's teachings" (Ubeysekara 2016). Humans can find Buddhist hope in these three, the so-called triple gem. Confidence cultivated by clarity of mind, removal of doubt, and direction of wisdom can lead to cessation of suffering. It dispels despair, doubt, and fear and may contribute to resilience and perseverance (Acharya 2002). All of them conditions for hope.

Rotman (2022a) expounded that *prasāda* means "clearness," "calmness," "graciousness," and "serene joy." But in the first interpretation of both *śraddhā* and *prasāda* there is a notion of a positive mental attitude, of inspiring emotions, and appreciation of serenity, clarity, and trust. On the other hand, Gethin (1992, p. 107) clarified that *śraddhā* is more of a positive response of trust in and confidence about something or somebody than a belief in something beyond knowledge. The function of *śraddhā* as defined in the *Visuddhimagga* by Buddhaghoṣa (5th century C.E.) is that it clears water like a legendary magical gem does—it leaps forward, it is like crossing a flood (Rotman 2022b). In the *Saundarananda of Aśvaghoṣa* (ca. 2nd century C.E.) *śraddhā* is described by the Buddha to half-brother Nanda in the following words: "From now onwards, dear, you should live your life in a way that is directed to a place where death is no longer, the mere fact that you now have the ability of trust (*śraddhā*) is in this now your messenger. Behave in such a way that the efforts of your body and words are pure, straightforward, open, protected and flawless" (Translation PVDV based on the edition of Johnston 1928, 13, 10–11).

However, *śraddhā* can be developed only after knowing or seeing that something is truly possible; it should be directed toward a target. And that implies hope.

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Rotman (2022b) argues that seeing is believing and to believe is to see. In other words, the Buddhist notion of hope should be supported by the known but maybe also further elevated by yet something so far unknown. The process from unknown to known gives rise to further hope. As Solnit (2016) reflects, "Hope just means another world might be possible, not promised, not guaranteed. Hope calls for action." This is the reason why so many Buddhists perform acts that produce positive karmic merits. Avoidance of unwholesome (*akusala*) acts and performance of wholesome (kusala), meritorious acts might result in a positive position in this life, but there are great expectations for a better afterlife or next life that will enable one to reach enlightenment in the end. After all, it was due to positive actions that the Buddha could finally reach a life in which he could reach his enlightenment. The accounts of his previous births, the so-called *jātaka* stories, are very popular in Asia as they show how the Buddha accumulated all of his merits to cause a life in which enlightenment and final liberation were possible. Hope for the better lies in trusting Buddhist teachings and practices. Later on we will discuss *anattā* (non-self) because an important matter here is the relationship between the old being that created the *karma* and the new being that arises out of this. Is it the same or not? Buddhism at least dares to doubt. This matter is connected to hope and compassion in Buddhism.

In the contemporary and worldly context, hope is indistinguishable from want or desire as in something tangible: (1) the hope (of/for something or for somebody) or hope (that or of doing) something that you wish for; (2) hope (of something or for somebody) a person, a thing, or a situation that will help you get what you want; or an intangible belief that something you want will happen. Hope can also be an action to want something to happen and think that it is possible (Oxford University Press, 2022). This hope may make us look forward to a better tomorrow instead of dwelling on the hardships of today. The world-famous Buddhist monk and social reformer Thich Nhat Hanh (1926–2022)—a good example of a modern researcher-practitioner—also reminds us this kind of hope posed this way could in the everyday world become "a kind of obstacle" because "we cling to our hope in the future, we do not focus our energies and capabilities on the present moment." Without hoping, we may be able to better discover the joy that is already here and enjoy ourselves fully in the present moment (Thich 1992, p.41). Hoping may thus be a pitfall in itself if only directed toward a faraway future.

But generally speaking, from a Buddhist perspective hope is beneficial and should be cultivated in the context of considering spiritual progress and transcending suffering as a possibility to be taken seriously. As explained in the authoritative Pāli *Upanisa Sutta* (*SN* 12.23), suffering could even be one of the supporting conditions for faith. This faith may lead to the Transcendental Order of Dependent Arising (Pāli: *lokuttara-paṭiccasamuppāda*, Sanskrit: *lokottara-pratītyasamutpāda*) of gladness, rapture, tranquility, happiness, concentration, knowledge and vision of things as they really are, revulsion, dispassion, liberation, and ultimately knowledge of destruction. One should know that Buddhism explains phenomena in the universe, if not the universe itself, out of laws of

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causality, out of causes that lead to a result. That result then once more is the cause for something else to happen. As opposed to the Mundane Order of Dependent Arising (Pāli: *paṭiccasamuppāda*, Sanskrit: *pratītyasamutpāda*), which denotes the endless cycles of sufferings, this Transcendental Order of Dependent Arising is indeed hopeful. Instead of leading to endless repetitions of variations of suffering, changing this train of causalities may end in positive results. A very important remark on this is made by Karunadasa (2015). He explained that a deeper understanding of impermanence means that because "there is change, there is possibility of changeability." The human personality is "plastic and pliable, and therefore wieldable and amenable to change" (p. 36). Read as such the fact that everything changes all the time, that nothing is permanent, shows another side. Usually, this continuous impermanence is seen as the main cause and form of suffering. But this very changeability implies the hope for change, the hope for the better, for well-being, for ultimate enlightenment. Luckily nothing is stern, monolithic, nor fixed. The Buddha explained that if there was a small portion of the psychophysical personality of a human being that was indeed permanent, even if it were as small as a pinch of dust, practicing the higher life would be of no avail. While an individual could be corrupted and external phenomenal existence could deteriorate, impermanence and dependent arising from the Buddhist perspectives imply that we can transcend suffering and impermanence in our spiritual pursuit.

Thus even in view of suffering, we should not despair because the doctrine of dependent arising means suffering is transformable; it can be skillfully applied—"where there is suffering, there is happiness, when there is light, there is also darkness like a twin brother. When there is despair, there is also hope" (Thich 2024). In Buddhist teachings, hope is dependently arising with despair like both sides of the same coin. In this aspect, hope is not a self-interest-driven desire nor merely materialistic. At least it should not necessarily be so. It is a spiritual and realistic pursuit to transcend mundane suffering and a wish for the well-being of oneself and others (Dalai Lama & Chodron 2017). The idea of hope also implies the ability to pursue virtuous works in an imperfect world filled with ambiguity and chaos. But it remains difficult to make perfect moral decisions. That is part of our world of *saṃsāra*.

As Bodhi (2013) explains, this transformation from suffering to awakening is neither natural nor spontaneous. It can be against our natural human tendencies. It must be practiced; it requires "a turn against the current" and "a break away from our instinctual urges for expansion and enjoyment and the embarkation in a different direction." The modern American Zen Buddhist teacher and researcher Joan Halifax quotes Shunryu Suzuki who vividly described how hope in one's life process is like "stepping onto a boat which is about to sail out to sea and sink"(Halifax 2018). A life of impermanence is a sinking ship. Yet one is still hopeful that one might make it to the other shore before the ship sinks or that it might be possible to switch ships to continue the journey. Nonetheless, this hope is not "blind hope." It is built upon a deep understanding of the wisdom of the already

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mentioned doctrine of dependent arising (*paṭiccasamuppāda*) and the laws of causality. The doctrine of dependent arising explains that Buddhism considers the world to be a continuously changing process; "there are only mental and material phenomena that arise in dependence on other mental and material phenomena, with no self-subsisting noumena as the ground of their being" (Karunadasa 2015, p. 5). In other words, "nothing arising from nothing, nothing arises from a single condition, nothing arises as a single conditioned factor. It is always the case that from a multiplicity of conditions arises a multiplicity of conditioned factors" (Karunadasa 2015, p. 30). This doctrine is the foundation of both change and transcendence. The laws of *karma* (generally accepted in both Buddhism and Hinduism) refer to the "effect of one's own actions performed in this or previous lives" (Woods 1998). *Karma* can be explained through three cardinal principles of Buddhist theory on moral life (Karunadasa 2015): (1) *kammavāda* (Pāli): advocacy of moral life and the recognition of moral consequences; the recognition that there is a causal correlation between what we do and what we reap; (2) *kiriyavāda* (Pāli): recognition of the need to do morally wholesome acts and to refrain from morally unwholesome acts; (3) *viriyavāda* (Pāli): recognition of and provision for the role of human effort in the pursuit of moral life. The hope of transcending suffering is built upon this understanding and on confidence in moral cultivation and the human efforts that are behind them.

It certainly cannot be considered blind hope here because it requires directed efforts and clarity. "What we do matters" (Halifax 2018). As Solnit (2016) clarifies, "Hope is not a lottery ticket you can sit on the sofa with and clutch, feeling lucky. It is an axe you break down doors with in an emergency." The Buddha invites us to "come and see" these principles ourselves. "We need to show up" no matter what (Halifax 2018). The Four Noble Truths[1] explaining the cause, origin, cessation, and the path leading to the cessation of suffering are truths because they are essentially the truths as seen by the practitioners before us (Ng 2020). As Thich (2022) taught, "With mindfulness we are no longer afraid of pain. We can even go further and make good use of suffering to generate the energy of understanding." It is also an active hope, not passive hope, because while we cannot control all the conditions, human efforts are essential contributing factors to transcendence. The Buddha as a teacher and a healer facilitates our understanding of the path leading to the cessation of suffering, but we have to walk through it ourselves. The Buddha taught his students in the *Kālāma Sutta* (AN 3.65) not to follow authorities, customs, or popular views blindly but actively discern what is skillful or unskillful to our welfare and happiness. We have to add here that the *Kālāma Sutta* is often quoted to invoke this idea of the importance of personal conviction expressed by the Buddha. On many other occasions, however, the Buddha has stated that

[1] These were preached by the Buddha just after his enlightenment in Sarnath to his five disciples. (1) There is *duḥkha* (Pāli: *dukkha*), imperfection, suffering. (2) There is a cause for *duḥkha*; it is caused by *tṛṣṇā*, i.e., our thirst for experiences (Pāli: *tanhā*). (3) This process can be stopped (in both Pāli and Sanskrit: *nirodhana*). (4) The path to stop this process is *mārga* (Pāli: *magga*). It consists of eight parts: right view, right resolve, right speech, right conduct, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, and right meditation.

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trust in his teachings and in his authority as a teacher is as important. Even though it is grounded on personal experience, hope in the Buddhist context is the courage to leap from the known to unknown, trusting that suffering can be transcended. This is possible for oneself as well as others. The conditions for this transcendence are reachable in spite of the fact that the results may not be immediately accessible.

Mahāyāna: The Bodhisattva, Compassion, and Hope

Later in Buddhism the "greater vehicle," or *Mahāyāna*, came into being. In this school hope takes a new shape. The older tradition of *Theravāda* is by many *Mahāyāna* Buddhists considered too limited, too self-centered, too individual. It is true that there were various reasons why the Buddha left the palace of his father and the luxurious life of his youth in pursuit of a truth that would remain. *Theravāda* will always assert that he did so not only for his own sake but also hoping to deliver his wife and son from suffering, if not all beings. Therefore this is often seen as an act of compassion. Yet most *Mahāyāna* Buddhists despite these conditions considered individual liberation an inferior target. If a person reached enlightenment and was delivered from suffering, he or she should once more engage in the world hoping to spread what was discovered. The hope for an end to suffering is to be shared. Just before entering the personal, final extinction of suffering, the enlightened being should look behind and see how creatures are suffering. The enlightened being should listen to their cries. He or she should return to the universe and spread the message of liberation. This is the new ideal set by the *Mahāyāna* school, that of the Bodhisattva, the "Enlightenment Being." Thus, countless beings can be delivered from suffering. That is true hope. Just like materialistic hope, in the eyes of *Mahāyāna* the too self-centered hope is to be abandoned (Dalai Lama & Chodron 2017). Hope lies in the vows that a Bodhisattva utters once he or she becomes aware of the enormous suffering of all sentient beings in the universe. The vows imply that the Bodhisattva will always work to assist others. The mere fact that a being can utter these Bodhisattva vows shows that reaching for enlightenment is within one's range. Otherwise, it would not even be possible to pronounce the words of the vows. One becomes a Bodhisattva by acting, by doing, by putting the vows into practice. Thus, as a Bodhisattva one aspires to reach enlightenment, but meanwhile the enlightened nature already shines through because one acts as an enlightened being. Thus one embodies the ideal already, even though one may be unaware of it. But acting thus, endless beings will receive the message. The mere fact that one *acts* as a Bodhisattva shows that the essence of enlightenment is already there, even though further refinement and fine-tuning are needed through countless lives. A Bodhisattva is characterized by an intriguing interaction of wisdom (*prajñā*) and compassion (*metta*, *karuṇā*, or *upāya*). Wisdom is inactive but inspires compassion. And a compassionate being is a wise being.

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This idea of "Bodhisattva like hope" also plays a part in politics. In ancient Cambodia there was King Jayavarman VII (1122–1218), who was a devoted *Mahāyāna* Buddhist. He identified himself with the great Bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara. His practice consisted of creating an ideal paradise-like realm. He had hospitals constructed for humans and animals, he had trees planted along the roads so that travelers could walk in the shade, and so on. Thus, he created an earthly paradise in the hope that a Bodhisattva would come down from heaven, because earth would be preferable above heaven. But he embodied that very Bodhisattva with his acts. What he hoped for he embodied himself. He transformed his Bodhisattva vows to everyday life. That is a hopeful form of *Mahāyāna* Buddhism in practice.

A particular form of *Mahāyāna* deserves attention here if it comes to hope. It is the so-called *pure land* Buddhism. In this school, very popular in China, Korea, and Japan, a practitioner hopes that he or she will be born in the paradise-like world of the enlightened Amida, also named *Amitābha*, the Buddha of the 'Western Paradise'. This paradise is called Sukhāvatī. A pure land practitioner also hopes that through actions he or she can transmit karmic merits to deceased ancestors or relatives in the hope that they will be born there in a more or less timeless bliss. Once more it is hope, wisdom, and compassion that play the major parts here. According to Baker (2005), the often-heard Japanese word *shinjin* (clear, pure heart) in pure land Buddhism denotes a heart and mind that entrusts itself to the saving power of Amida's Vow. This faith and trust in the saving power of Amida's Vow carries with it an essence of hope as one looks forward to the consummation of his salvation in the Pure Land." Dake (2013) sees Amida the embodiment of hope as invoked by the Japanese teacher Shinran (1173–1263).

In *Vajrayāna* Buddhism the Bodhisattva ideal plays a similar part like it does in *Mahāyāna*. The enlightened being in *Vajrayāna* likewise longs for the cessation of suffering of all beings. The *Vajrayāna* saint, however, can go far when it comes to reaching for enlightenment. There are many divisions in *Vajrayāna*, but in the more extreme schools hope for enlightenment lies in the disruption of the normal. An extreme *Vajrayāna* practitioner may go as far as to transgress each and every border of society, even legal institutions. The idea behind this is that as long as one restricts oneself to the rules and regulations of society, this will keep you bound up in the world of *samsāra*, the world of incarnations and suffering. Extreme *Vajrayāna* practitioners may become criminals, as the ideal is to be found in disruption of the everyday common order. For them the lower forms of longing and desires, generally rejected in Buddhism, as described in the beginning of this section, can be the very vehicle through the skillful application of which they can reach enlightenment. But that is quite unusual. Now we have to say that most of the ideal saint's histories of *Vajrayāna* are legendary and half mythological, but the stories do play. They are told, remembered, and studied. Hope for enlightenment, hope for improvement is to be found in the unexpected, in the extreme, in the bizarre, which suddenly takes you out of your comfort zone and confronts you with the mere essence of what it is supposed to be. Shocking though this experience may be.

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But generally speaking of hope in Buddhism, if the spiritual, compassionate, and wisdom-based hope corresponds to confidence and faith in Buddhist teachings and practices, the materialistic, self-centered, and unreasoned hope corresponds to a undesired if not delusional desire. The former as an informed active hope (Macy & Johnstone 2022) is significantly different from Western theistic thinking about hope (King 2013; Willis 2017). Active hope is a practice focusing on what we *do* instead of *have*. It is the capacity and commitment to focus on our intentions and *choose* how to proceed even in hopelessness. It is surely not simply sit and wait. "Active hope is about becoming active participants in bringing about what we hope for" (Macy & Johnstone 2022, p. 4). It is not an "effective ethical management" (King 2013). The latter is considered as a blind passive hope and even theistic (Gombrich 2013). It is considered as ineffective and irresponsible (Willis 2017). Hope in the former sense is therefore integral to Buddhist teachings. Halifax (2018) interpreted active hope as "wise" hope while passive hope is considered ordinary hope. Wise hope is "born of radical uncertainty, rooted in the unknown and the unknowable … [it is] seeing things as they are, including the truth of impermanence … as well as the truth of suffering—both its existence and the possibility of its transformation, for better or for worse."

It will be clear from the above that Buddhism in its manifold shapes, currents, and schools is thus permeated with hope. This concerns hope not only for personal development but caring for others as well. Hope can coexist with confidence and knowledge (King 2013). Indeed, hope can be nurtured by moral discipline, wisdom, and mindfulness. King (2013, p. 180) argued that Buddhist hope is "based in acceptance of what is, in knowledge of the reality of change and the lawful workings of cause and effect, in an optimistic view of human nature and trust in the power of Truth." With the right practice, change is possible for oneself and for the external world and therefore offers the possibility of hope. Hope is in essence an individual's own cultivation, as well as facilitating other's transformation in the context of pastoral services (Ng 2016). It is linked to our respect for the Buddha nature in oneself and in others. It is therefore possible to cultivate hope and offer hope—not offering a false and blind wish but the deep understanding and practice to facilitate hope in despair, offering comfort, strength, and stability following the practices of wisdom and compassion illustrated by the Buddha.

In Buddhism, cessation of suffering, *nibbāna* (Sanskrit*: nirvāṇa*, the extinction of the fires of the passions), is possible through the Threefold Trainings and Noble Eightfold Path comprising moral discipline, mental concentration, and wisdom. Liberation is achieved through the cessation of suffering through the cessation of wrong views and hence moral cultivation, mindfulness, and wisdom based on a profound understanding that sufferings and conflicts arise because of erroneously identifying our "self" with the impermanent (Ng 2020). *Nibbāna* is possible through a deep understanding and practice of non-self (Pāli: *anattā*, Sanskrit: *anātman*) and impermanence (Pāli: *anicca*, Sanskrit: *anitya*).

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Hindu Perspectives of Hope

Hinduism has some beliefs quite in common with Buddhism yet differs from it in several ways. Both generally agree on the laws of *karma* and reincarnation, or at least lives following one another due to causality, and they both believe in the possibility of liberation and release from endless cycles of birth, sickness, aging, death, and rebirth in *samsāra*. Reincarnation implies suffering and imperfection. Life in this everyday world will never be perfect. Or at least, any attempt to make it perfect is very complicated. But Hinduism has endless forms, beliefs, myths, and practices. There is passionate devotion in which the state of ecstasy plays an important part. Meanwhile there can be severe asceticism. There can be solemn rituals. There are many forms of Hindu theism, the realm of the Hindu gods may seem to be endless, meanwhile there can be monism or even monotheism. Gods can be active agents who have distinctive features, iconography, and myths, meanwhile the divine can be beyond forms and concepts. But for sure there are things commonly shared by Hinduism and Buddhism. They share at times the same myths, stories, symbols. For instance, in both traditions the lotus flower symbolizes hope as it remains pure and untouched by the muddy waters surrounding it. In both the lotus flower can be seen as a symbol of hope as it demonstrates the possibility to rise above suffering and achieve spiritual liberation. This liberation called *mokṣa* in Hinduism is possible through detachment from worldly feelings and perceptions. Sometimes this can be reached by connecting and even merging with the universal *brahman.* This *brahman* is a force or a spiritual ground that pervades the entire universe. The idea is that each and every being has a personal eternal soul named *ātman.* This *ātman* is for some reason disconnected from *brahman* but needs to find its way back. If that track is found the merging will be there and liberation will follow. Other Hindus strive after an eternal life in one of the heavenly abodes in the presence of the manifold gods. Liberation from suffering in Hinduism has countless forms, and one can imagine the manifold forms hope may therefore have.

If one asked Hindus what they consider to be their Hinduism, one is likely to get an answer in which words occur like "*dharma*," "*yoga*," or "*mārga*." These concepts are crucial in Hinduism. All three have their connection to hope, and that is why we bring in these concepts here. The term *dharma* in Hinduism does not refer to the teachings of the Buddha. In Hinduism, *dharma* implies a world order, a structure in the world. The universe revolves around a certain order to which all creatures and phenomena are connected. If the *dharma* is ideal, there is in fact nothing to hope for, for the universe is perfect then. Hinduism does not have a word for "religion," but the term *dharma* comes close to it. Each and every phenomenon in the universe has its *dharma*, its order. Each and everything is connected. Therefore, it is an important idea in Hinduism that one should follow one's *dharma*, often called *svadharma*, "one's proper dharma." Denying one's *dharma* implies disruption of the universe and ends up in chaos. That is the end of all hope of course. It is a fixed idea that when the universe was just created *dharma* was perfected. There was no

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evil, no greed, and death did not exist. In that situation *dharma* is compared to a strong four-footed bull, standing firm. But things get out of hand. Evil comes into being, and slowly things become worse. At present we live in a period in which the *dharma* is like a bull with only one foot left. What Hindus hope for is a restoration of the glorious past in the future. "Make the future as it was!" so to say. In the future the universe will be destroyed once the *dharma* has completely reached its worst. Then it will be recreated, and it will once more be perfect. That is what Hindus in general hope for. Hence the enormous emphasis on following the correct *dharma* instructions. Healing the *dharma* consists of following the *dharma*.

Then there is the term "*yoga*." Of course, nowadays this word invokes the modern practice of complicated physical postures, named the *āsana*s, but in fact *yoga* is a much older concept within Hindu practice. For that matter, the word can also be found referring to Buddhist practices. *Yoga* as a term above all refers to *methodological exertion* or *methodological effort*. It is the practice that will lead to a desired result, a result hoped for. In fact, as a concept *yoga* is related to the term *mārga*. *Mārga* means "path," "way," or "route." It is the same word that is used for the eightfold path of Buddhism, the *mārga* (*magga* in Pāli) that the Buddha spoke of. All of these terms imply a methodology that will lead to a result, a result hoped for.

Hinduism has endless *yoga*s and *mārga*s. It is the reason why Hindus perform particular rituals, why they go on pilgrimages. They do all this hoping for a positive reward, for karmic merits, karmic results. In the end they hope for *mokṣa*, final liberation in whatever form. Of course, these *mārga*s, *yoga*s, and so on are described in *dharma* instructions in the form of sacred scriptures. But there are other *dharma* authorities as well. For instance, elderly family members, living *guru*s, or modern saints.

It is impossible in this contribution to give a complete overview of how these concepts are all connected to hope. But we can look closer at one of the most important Hindu sacred scriptures on this subject, the Bhagavad Gītā. In this text, which nowadays is especially central in modern Hinduism, *dharma* is discussed in a conversation of the prominent god Krishna with his friend Arjuna. Arjuna raises the fair question what a human should do in life. Should a human act, fully aware that each and every action has karmic results and therefore liberation will never follow? Or should one refrain from acting and live the life of an ascetic to avoid any accumulation of *karma*?

Krishna answers him and talks about three *yoga*'s or *mārga*'s. Each one of these *mārga*'s will lead to a desired result. In each one of them there is hope. First there is the path of action: *karma yoga* or *karma mārga*. This path consists of methodological acting. One should perform the tasks that are connected to one's position in life. A nobleman or *kṣatriya* as Arjuna is, should lawfully fight his enemies for the benefit of the universe. It is his *svadharma* to do so. But this actor should not cling to the results of these actions. If the person who acts dedicates the karmic fruits of his acting to Krishna, there will be no negative karmic results. In the end by thus acting, there is hope for final liberation. That is why acting (*karma*) can be seen as

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a *yoga*, as a *mārga*, that will lead to the result desired. That is the hope in the way of acting.

Next there is the path of knowledge, of mental realization. It is named *jñāna mārga* or *jñāna yoga.* It is the path of concentration, of meditation out of which a profound realization comes forward that the individual soul or self (*ātman*) is nothing as such. The experience of a personal self can be seen as a situation of illusion (*māyā*). Final liberation or enlightenment consists of the realization that the *ātman* coincides with *brahman*, which we have mentioned already. But if it comes to the relation of *ātman* with *brahman* and the role of *māyā*, there are many variations.

The last one is the path of devotion: *bhakti mārga* or *bhakti yoga.* It has many forms but in the Bhagavad Gītā, all consist of surrender to Krishna himself. It consists, among things, of surrendering all one's deeds to Krishna. Then liberation will follow. And that is hopeful. There is *bhakti* to other Hindu gods as well, to Śiva and to the manifold forms of the goddess for instance.

According to Gokhale (2021), this connection between the soul and the universe is partly supported by devotion, *bhakti*, which is the "relationship of love and attachment that a devotee feels toward God." But *bhakti* is a gradual process; there are many aspects of this path. Sometimes different gradings of *bhakti* are spoken of, from the (1) one in distress (*ārta*), (2) one desirous of realization (*jijñāsu*), (3) the one desirous of wealth (*arthārthī*), and (4) one who has realized the truth (*jñānī*). Realizing the truth is realizing god—an ideal stage when the devotee and god are indistinguishable. For this devotional relationship to be possible, the devotional object is considered real and ideal, which should be "real" and "existent in its transcendent form" (Gokhale 2021, p. 151) even if it is not physically present. On the other hand, from a religious perspective, the devotional object "possesses ideal qualities such as omnipotence and omniscience, as well as other good qualities such as beauty, wealth and kindness" (Gokhale 2021, p. 151). Having said that, the devotional object is not necessarily "existent and ideal." What is necessary is "a strong belief or faith—generally an uncritical faith—in the existence and the ideal nature of the devotional object." While *bhakti* is not exactly hope in the contemporary sense, it is definitely transcendental and ideal, fulling the devotee's wishes and alleviating their sufferings.

But in Hinduism, *bhakti* is also "hopeful," as the relationship between god and devotee is reciprocal. Gokhale (2021) explained that the acts of *bhakti* are "presented with the hope that they will be reciprocated by the devotional object." The devotees' utmost love for god is reciprocated by the god's great compassion. Seshagiri Rao (1974, p. 178) argues that *śraddhā*, faith, trust, in Hinduism refers to an "aspiration of the heart for a transcendent goal … a confidence in some appropriate 'means' (*sādhana*) to reach that goal … [and] a reliance on the *śāstra* (i.e. the sacred scriptures) for the knowledge of both … the goal and the means." The path of *bhakti* can be very systematic. For instance, in accordance with the *Tripura Rahasya* (Venkataramaiah 2006), a practitioner could learn and practice under

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his master through a scheme of liberation, gaining first the theoretical knowledge and then practice knowledge through deep reflections. "He is able to ascertain the highest truth with clearness and certitude … be able to identify the Self with the Supreme and thus destroy the root of ignorance." Shankara urges the realization of this inner self: just as "the air in a jar is one with the air everywhere … your *Ātman* is one with Brahman" (Prabhavananda & Isherwood 1971, p. 94). One could "gain experience directly. Realize God for yourself. Know the *Ātman* as the one indivisible Being, and become perfect." Instead of taking pleasure and desire through this body, one should "free your mind from all distractions and dwell in the consciousness of the *Ātman*" (Prabhavananda & Isherwood 1971, p. 131).

Similar to our earlier discussion on faith from the Buddhist perspective, another important feature of *bhakti* is that it seems to be quite different from other paths of liberation with respect to emotions and attachments. *Bhakti yoga* "welcomes the emotional dimension of a person and tries to channel it and transform it into the vehicle leading to liberation." It also recommends "intense attachment to the devotional object" (Gokhale 2021, p. 152).

While *bhakti* is not identified with blind hope, it is also not the same as the active hope in the Buddhist context. Another already mentioned word related to hope and faith, *śraddhā* could be understood as "to place" a "wager" or "to put" one's "heart on something" in the context of Hinduism in general (Rotman 2022b). Turci (2021, p. 86) explained further that *śraddhā* is defined as "trusting judgement, or affirmative conviction—*āstikya-buddhi*." As Turci elaborates (2015, p. 5), *śraddhā* is

> is a symbol of illumination and revealer of truth. Arising from the vital stimuli received from the soul (*ātman*) through its representative (i.e., *buddhi*, the power of forming and retaining conceptions; intellect, reason, discernment, and so on), *śraddhā* is a "material" phenomenon manifested as energy in our body.

Smith (1979) elucidates that *śraddhā* is linked with "*buddhi*" instead of "*manas*." Hence, it is not simply the mind, believing, or giving mental assent to something, but the "awakeness to transcendence" that belongs to the higher visionary self in the "heart" and not to the rational mind or *manas*.

Then there is this other concept in Hinduism *prasādha, grace*. The same word *prasāda* refers to the "food that has been offered to images of the gods" (Rotman 2022a). This last meaning plays above all in Hinduism, less in Buddhism. The food consumed by the god contains the lowest "uncleanliness" of that god. The food offered and consumed by the god is now "polluted" with his or her saliva. But that is the highest we as humans can ever get. In this particular *prasāda* lies our hope. The same goes for the "dust on the feet of the gods." The lowest of the gods is the highest we can ever get. And that is grace.

Veylanswarmi (2009) argues that there are three stages of faith in Hinduism. From the initial stage solely based on belief that could be easily shaken or destroyed

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to the second stage based on philosophical knowledge. There is strong support of reasoning and thoughts to make faith less easily disturbed. The third stage is like a full-grown tree that can withstand external challenges nurtured by personal experience of god. While there is hope for liberation from suffering through the realization of *ātman* and *brahman*, "to realize one's true oneness with the cosmos is to pass beyond personality" (Burnett 2002, p. 72). This may seem to suggest that there is no place for hope if there is no individual or personality there being the one who hopes. The Bhagavad Gītā proclaims that when our intellects transcend delusions, we "will become indifferent to the results of all action, present or future" (Prabhavananda & Isherwood 1951, p. 41).

Ātman and *Anātman (anattā)*

A fundamental difference between Hinduism and Buddhism is that there is no eternal self in Buddhism, not even a sort of universal being. Buddhist teaching on the characteristics of non-self (*anattā*) is inseparable from the realization of impermanence (*anicca*) and suffering. Realization according to Buddhist teachings means the realization what is impermanent is suffering (*yad aniccaṃ; taṃ; dukkhaṃ;*); what is suffering is non-self (Pāli: *yaṃ; dukkhaṃ; tad anattā*) (Karunadasa 2015). In Buddhism hope lies in this understanding, in this realization that will finally lead to enlightenment and the cessation of all suffering. In Hinduism the *ātman* is eternal. In Hinduism hope can take on many forms, but in many cases it implies a mingling with the divine, be it in a complete merging or in a merging with a heavenly abode where one can meet and mingle with one of the gods. Then the *ātman* reaches its ultimate destination.

Hindu God's Prevalence and the Caste System

Hinduism has a strong notion of hierarchical structure in the caste system, explaining why people of society should belong to differently defined and immobile social classes based on the accumulated merit in past lives (Madan 2023). Moreover, Hinduism places strong emphasis on appropriate behavior in accordance with different life stages and different statuses in the caste system. The "lifestyle, occupation and even food a Hindu eats are designated" (Burnett 2002, p. 71), at least in principle. Everyday practice can be different. Accordingly, the possibility of transcendence and hope is also limited by the caste system. At least it is limited in this life. In the afterlife or the next life it can be different. But of course, as one can imagine, this basic idea may restrict one to think about hope and liberation from a low position in this present life. In Buddhism, this is different, in principle at least. In practice there are high-caste and low-caste Buddhist monasteries in countries where the caste system exists, for instance Sri Lanka. But is true, Buddha taught that "birth makes no distinctive mark . . . Distinction among human beings

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is purely verbal designation" (MN 98). It is definitely hope by human action, not by designation or birth, that allows meritocracy, human efforts in this life time, and mobility across different social classes or functions of humans depending on their capabilities, efforts, and merits. This is especially true within the Buddhist *saṅgha*, but we have to keep in mind that within Asian Buddhism men are always higher valued than women. The youngest, just initiated monk is above the eldest nun in rank. While the Hindu social system may be bounded by the caste system in this lifetime, God is analogous to the sun that shines equally on everyone, regardless of social class, gender, good or evil, or even religious belief. God is all pervading in Hinduism. He is "boundless and unlimited. God removes the pain and suffering as he is conscious of our difficulties, remaining unaffected … He is omnipresent in this multifarious universe" (Kasturi & Kasturi 2013, p. 203). No one is chosen or special in the eyes of the gods. We could cultivate a personal relationship with the gods under the guidance of the *gurus*.

Bhakti surely plays a part with respect to the Buddhas and Bodhisattvas in the *Mahāyāna* and *Vajrayāna* Buddhism, but it is generally quite ignored or underemphasized in early Buddhist teachings, where devotion to the Buddha's teaching is more important than devotion to the Buddha as a person (Gokhale 2021). Even the teaching of the Buddha is subject to examination as discussed in the *Kālāma Sutta* (AN 3.65). Buddha had offered detailed teachings on how to gain insight/knowledge and realize emancipation through critical study of relevant discourses and *dharma* teachings and then "put [them] to the test by actual practice" (Pāsādika 2021, p. 312). Since the Buddha is only the guide or the demonstrator of the Noble Path, he is not offering liberation in response to the devotees' hope or faith in the path. At least not in early Buddhism. This changes later on in the schools that afterward came to be. The devotees have to follow the path and practice the *dharma* accordingly. Still the essence of reciprocity as found in Hinduism is less present in Buddhism. The Buddha's and Bodhisattva's loving kindness (Pāli: *metta*) and compassion (Pāli: *karuṇā*) are immeasurable in Buddhist teachings. Their qualities are for all beings and not first conditioned or dependent on the personal devotional relationship. Nevertheless, as Gokhale (2021) argues, the devotional school does suggest that *bhakti* by itself could be a path superseding the purification of the mind or moral action. It is however above all part of the *Mahāyāna* and *Vajrayāna* teachings of Buddhism.

Comparing Hinduism and Buddhism, *Karma*, Human Efforts, and Hope

As stated above, Hinduism and Buddhism have a lot in common, but there are differences as well. Most Hindus and Buddhists believe in *karma*. In a way the conditions of your present life are fixed. But this does not imply that nothing could or should change. To put it in a comparison more often made in Indian thinking, a tiger can become dirty, he can become old or wet, but he can never become a lion.

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This is because the potentiality to become so is not there. A human, or for that matter any being, is born in such and such circumstances, in a particular embodiment, in a country, in a family or rich or poor. These conditions are fixed. They are the result of *karma* from a past life. But freedom, and therefore hope, lies in the efforts one undertakes. Given all of these circumstances a human, for instance, can try to improve the conditions for themselves and for others. Especially through social engagement one can work on spiritual rewards, on positive karmic merits. This will result in better life circumstances in the future. This might concern one's present life situation but for certain the condition for future life or lives. That is hopeful. Yet we may often find, especially in popular imagining in the West, the idea that Hindus and Buddhists are not interested nor engaged in social works or something of that kind, as it is supposed to be useless. That definitely is not true. Sometimes one may also find ideas that if Hindus or Buddhists are engaged in social work this is only for selfish reasons, as they are only doing so with their eyes set on future rewards. That as well is not how Hindus and Buddhists visualize ideal life, ideal society, or human flourishing. There is always hope for improvement, hope for a better future. This future is often considered to coincide with a glorious past. "Make the future as it was," as we have seen above. Human efforts are not useless in an up-to-a-certain-degree preconditioned world. In the West one may sometimes come across ideas that Hindus and Buddhists are not interested in social work, as this would disrupt an individual's karmic process. *Karma* should have its own way to reach its results. If someone is poor or sick, this is due to bad *karma* and that karmic "fruit" should come to its results. You do not help a person from a karmic spiritual point of view if you assist this person, so to say. But this is not what we find in the reality of Asia. Human efforts have concrete meaning and effect in Buddhist and Hindu thinking. Rituals have their effects, taking on the monastic vows as a Buddhist monk or nun, even if it is for a limited period, or social work in whatever form; these practices give one the possibility to affect the life one is living or is going to live. And you help others by it.

A difference between Hinduism and Buddhism concerns the already mentioned imaginations of the "self" or "soul" in each and every creature. In Hinduism the self (*ātman*) is generally considered eternal. It exists in its individual form until it merges with the universal soul or force of *brahman*. Then the *ātman* has changed, but the *brahman* as well. Buddhism does not accept the soul as something permanent. Each and every phenomenon is changing, which is called *anitya* (Pāli: *anicca*). This same impermanence characterizes the self. This is the above-mentioned *anātman* (Pāli: *anattā*). In Buddhism, therefore, one cannot say that the creature that arises out of the old *karma* is the very same as the creature that created the *karma*. The Buddha would give the instruction that one cannot say it is the same, but meanwhile one can likewise not say it is different. The one comes into being out of the *karma* of the other. This not only happens at the moment of death, but it also happens each and every moment. This may sound negative, but meanwhile it is freedom, as this conditions

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that change is indeed possible. Therefore, Siddhārtha Gautama, an unenlightened human who was a noble's son, could develop himself and change into the enlightened Buddha. Change is possible and that implies hope. You do not want a creature to arise out of your past *karma* that is once more going to suffer. You are a compassionate being after all. At least you should be a compassionate being.

In Hinduism there is yet another aspect of *karma* that one may come across. According to some currents in Hinduism, *karma* is the fastest way back to the divinity, back to the company of the god. This is often found in the *bhakti* traditions where a personal god is central. In some forms of Śaivism one may find the image of the god Śiva, the Lord (*pati*), who holds a rope (*pāśa*) that is attached to a bull (*paśu*). The god is Śiva, the bull is the soul, the rope is *karma* in this image. *Karma*, the rope, is thus the direct connection to the godhead and the fastest way back to this god. Moreover, just like in Buddhism some Bodhisattva's are able to remove evil *karma*; likewise some of the Hindu gods are supposed to be able to set one free from past *karma*. All of a sudden, the strict rules of *karma* do not work anymore. Gods, Buddhas, and Bodhisattvas are beyond the normal, beyond the strict rules of the universe. Both Hinduism and Buddhism have their major sins (*mahāpāpa*) that supposedly can never be eradicated. In Hinduism these are killing a brahmin, stealing gold, drinking liquor, killing one's parents, and having sex with the wife of one's teacher. There are variations. In Buddhism the major sins are killing your father or mother, killing or hurting a Buddha or an enlightened human (*arhat*), causing a schism in the *saṅgha*. Here as well there are differences. The first five rules of the *Vinaya* are often mentioned as well; killing, stealing, lying, sexual misconduct, and drinking alcohol. These are strict but if transgressed, they can sometimes be settled. After all, sometimes a soldier has to kill enemies. Yet a Hindu god can remove these karmic sins; a Buddha or Bodhisattva can sometimes do likewise. In Japanese Buddhism there is the popular Bodhisattva Jizo (*Kṣitigarbha*, or the Earth Store) who will plead for those who are about to be judged by Emma-O, the god of death. Emma-O can be rigid, but Jizo will save the creatures, even those who committed grave sins. But once more *śraddhā*, trust is important. This all is hopeful.

Conclusion: Buddhist and Hindu Hope in Contemporary Research

In both traditions hope gives humanity purpose, strength, and courage. In the modern context, hope may take on the shape of positive emotions. This can broaden an individual's capacities and resources to strengthen awareness, gather thoughts, and support action (Frederickson, 1998). It may lay the foundation for further developments and transcendence. As discussed earlier, hope from the Buddhist and Hindu perspectives has emotional dimensions, a feeling of possibilities, confidence, and trust that can bridge the known and unknown. The broaden-and-

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build theory of positive emotions also supports this argument and illustrates how positive emotions can support broadening our thought-action repertoires.

Contemporary discussions reinforce Buddhist and Hindu perspectives of hope as a character and skill set that can be practiced and cultivated. It is possible to cultivate skillful hope through action and commitment. It is "a capacity to hold the truth of our lives, whether that reality is painful or pleasurable" (Valarie 2022, p. 8). According to Macy and Johnstone (2022, p. 4), active hope is a practice. In the work-that-reconnects model, hope could be developed through a four stages spiral: (1) coming from gratitude, (2) honoring our pain for the world, (3) seeing with new eyes, and (3) going forth. In what Halifax (2018) called the "wise hope," cultivation "requires that we open ourselves to what we do not know, what we cannot know … and this is the space in which we can engage." It is realistic and fathomable to hope for a world of healing and peace.

Contemporary scholars Scioli et al. (2011, p. 79) define hope "as a future-directed, four channel emotion network, constructed from biological, psychological, and social resources." The four channels are mastery, attachment, survival, and spiritual systems that work together and inspire and feed one another. They suggest that the hope network is a deep structure "designed to regulate these systems via both feed-forward (expansion) and feedback processes (maintenance) that generate a greater perceived probability of power and presence as well as protection and liberation." They identify the conceptions of hope across disciplines such as nursing, philosophy, psychology, psychiatry, and theology (Scioli et al. 2011), while Sandra and Nandram (2020) have also explored the significance of hope/faith in spiritual leadership. Scioli et al. (2011) suggest that hope scales could be applied as clinical measurements to evaluate the impact of introducing or supporting cultivation of hope like a "shot" or the "best medicine" in psychotherapy. While it is very helpful to develop measurements to quantify and measure hope, it is also very challenging to measure hope from the spiritual perspective, particularly when it does not only relate to the mind or mood but also something to the "heart" and the "awakeness to transcendence" as discussed earlier.

Indeed, it could be difficult to confine Buddhist hope to survival motive or Hindu hope to survival and mastery motives, as attempted by Scioli and Biller (2009). However, both Buddhism and Hinduism do not uphold the primacy of one only true god (Kirsch 2004): There are countless god like beings in the Buddhist heavens, but there is no unique prime god in Buddhism, and there are many gods (the realization of *ātman* and *brahman*) in Hinduism. In this world of uncertainty, chaos, and desperation, both Buddhism and Hinduism offer different perspectives on hope that may contribute to deeper tolerance and diversity. A few studies have explored potential contributions in the cultivation of positive psychology and mental health by Buddhism (Lee and Oh 2019; Gao et al. 2022; Zuihō Segall & Kristeller 2023) and Hinduism (Singh et al. 2023), but research on hope is still scanty. Further research on understanding and evaluating the influence and mechanisms of these traditions, quantitatively or qualitatively, on hope would be

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invaluable (Scioli 2020), particularly in the context of spiritual and religious care in healthcare settings. These two ancient traditions may source and practice hope differently, but they will continue to contribute to hope amidst hopelessness for mankind.

Abbreviations

AN *Aṅguttara Nikāya*, the "numerical" discourses.
CDB *The Connected Discourses of the Buddha* (translation of *SN*; see Bodhi 2000).
MLDB *The Middle Length Discourses of the Buddha* (translation of *MN*; see Ñanamoli & Bodhi 1995).
NDB *The Numerical Discourse of the Buddha* (translation of *AN*; see Bodhi 2012).
SN *Saṃyutta Nikāya*, the "connected" discourses.

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